

COMPANY of HEROES™



Heroism Pvt. Ltd.

Another RTS game based on WWII. Big deal. But to call *Company of Heroes* (COH) just another RTS game would be sacrilege—the game is as gripping and visceral as any first person shooter out there, and very nearly as visually stunning. A gorgeous graphics engine under the hood always sets the right tone, and COH looks amazing for any genre (especially the typically bland RTS), with realistic aftermath effects like fire, smoke, and fog to match the combat effects and explosions. Unit detailing is phenomenal, and I spent quite a bit of time just zooming in and panning around!

Add to the splendid visuals a real killer audio experience that brings the battlefield to vivid life—I could very nearly imagine myself there (All right, so I got carried away!).

Gameplay is where COH really packs a wallop, with great mission depth and variety that don't always come together in RTS games today. There's a nice collection of both the units and the situations you find yourself embroiled in. In the usual RTS style, certain units counter others rather well and are weak against other units: a sniper might

excel against infantry squads, especially if he's garrisoned in a tall building, but will fail miserably to impress against an armoured car!

The cutscenes are compelling: they actually feel like they're integral to the story, and not just afterthought-additions.

Unlike many other RTSes, COH involves goodly doses of both resource garnering (through capturing and holding sectors, similar to the *Dawn of War* 40K series) and tactical combat situations, and you'll find yourself challenged equally by

these activities. A mundane resource-point capture can become a struggle for survival as enemies swarm out of the fog of war. You'll also be challenged while advancing with your entire army, as you need to handle tactical situations. For example, advancing with tanks, though prudent—to protect vulnerable infantry—may not always be the best way out: a couple of squads of Nazis with bazookas in a choke point position can easily take out a tank or two before you can eliminate them. Similarly, using a squad to scout could prove costly if the Krauts have a couple of snipers on high ground. The game encourages you to actually think before making a move, and then think some more!

I can account for more than a few sleepless nights spent huddled in front of my monitor courtesy *Company of Heroes*. A great concept that's been implemented to perfection! On a negative note, you'll need a killer rig to run COH, and if you're running anything less than 2 GB of memory, expect to see long load times and frame drops, regardless of your graphics card.

Quite simply, if your machine is up to the challenge, join the war!

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Rating: **9/10**

Developer: **Relic**

Publisher: **THQ**

Minimum System Requirements: **Pentium 4 1.8 GHz, 512 MB RAM, 128 MB Direct X9 compatible graphics card**

